HUMS508 Cover Sheet

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The Pyramid Texts and the Journey to the Afterlife

As he lay dying Unas [1], last Pharaoh [2] of the Fifth Dynasty (c. 2375-2345 B.C.) of Egypt's Old Kingdom (Malek, 2000, p. 100) would not have viewed his impending death as the final step in his existence, leading to oblivion. Death was just one step on his journey to the afterlife; Pyramid Text (PT) 211[3] describing how Unas would go "…forth to the sky…" and live with the gods. (Allen, 2005, p. 57)(Allan, 1989, p. 1) The preparations for this journey were well in hand, having begun shortly after Unas's ascension to the throne.

The building of a suitable funerary monument for Pharaoh was a tradition begun in the late Predynastic Period, where the need to display the power and privilege attained by the elite levels of society extended to lavish burials – such as Tomb 100 at Hierakonpolis, (Dodson & Ikram, 2008, p. 133) – with these burials visible symbols of the "…social and economic control…" wielded by the elite of society. (Bard, 1992, p. 3) Following on from the traditions of his Old Kingdom, pyramid building, predecessors, Unas commissioned the building and decoration of his pyramid. (Figure 1) (Rice, 2003, pp. 160-162)



Figure 1 Pyramid of Unas
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A belief in the afterlife, and a perceived need to provide the deceased with provisions for their life in the next world, was not new; burials from the Predynastic period have

[1] References discussing Unas over the last 100 years have used various iterations of his name, including Unis, Wenis and Wanas; for this paper the spelling to be utilised will be Unas.
[2] Rulers of Egypt from the Predynastic Period through to the Old Kingdom, depending on the reference, are variously referred to as King or Pharaoh; this paper will use Pharaoh.
[3] All Pyramid Text (PT) quotes in this paper will be from Allen, J.P., *The Ancient Egyptian Pyramid Texts*, 2005.

been found with grave goods, such as jewellery, cosmetics and weapons in female burials and weapons in male burials. (Midant-Reynes, 2000, pp. 187-188)(Bard, 1992, p. 3) While expensive grave goods, as befitting his status, would have been provided for Unas, he also introduced a unique – and personal – innovation to his tomb by ordering the interior walls of his pyramid (Figure 2) be carved with religious spells that would both provide for his needs in, and ensure his safe passage to, the afterlife. (Malek, 2000, pp. 102-103)

The spells – known as utterances (Lichtheim, 2006, p. 29) – provided Unas with the food, drink, clothing and power he needed to sustain him in the afterlife; and also protected him from malevolent spirits seeking to harm him on his journey. The use of both offering and protection spells would not have been seen as unique; the offering spells for food and drink were akin to the existing custom of providing grave goods; and the protection spells were likely those used in burial ceremonies in the Predynastic period c. 4000 B.C. (Wilkinson, T., 2003, p. 122) As well as ensuring Unas' safe passage to the afterlife, the spells gave him omnipotence over mortals and the gods – Unas would remain all powerful in death as in life. (Wilkinson, T., 2010, pp. 87-89)



Figure 2 Unas' burial chamber with Pyramid Texts on walls
Source: www.proteus.brown.edu Accessed 29 Mar 2013

The passages carved on the interior walls of the chambers of Unas' pyramid are now known as the Pyramid Texts (the Texts). (Strudwick, 2005, p. 1) The Texts were not original works commissioned by, or composed specifically for, Unas; instead they are the first rendition in stone of religious texts, some of which were originally recited at Predynastic burial ceremonies, (Rice, 2003, p. 208)(Hays, 2011, KL 3743-3745).[4] These

[4] KL indicates the Kindle Location number for the reference – some Kindle Book editions do not include page numbers, instead only location numbers within each chapter are provided.

utterances are a unique relic from this period in history; and also in the context that Egypt is the only ancient civilization where sacred writings of this type have survived to be examined. In addition, the Texts are also the only surviving, primary source documents capable of providing an insight into the general culture of Egyptian society from the time of Old Kingdom Egypt; including the developing moral and ethical notions of "…judgement, justification and immortality..." (Karenga, 2006, pp. 29-30)(Allen, 2005, p. 1)

Additionally, as the oldest, extant, body of religious and funerary literature, the Texts are the only ancient source from which the evolution of the theology and mortuary rituals surrounding the death of an Old Kingdom Pharaoh can be analysed. (Hornung, 1999, p. 1)(Malek, 2000, pp. 102-103)(Dunand & Zivie-Coche, 2004, p. 184) These rituals originated in the Predynastic Period and were based on the "…institution of the king…" his mortuary cult and funerary monuments. (Bard, 1992, p. 5) Theology may be perceived as being only a component of religions which have as their basis a *formal* corpus, such as Christianity with the Bible or Islam with the Koran, and *not* a cult-based religion (Assmann, 2001, p. ix) as developed in Egypt from the Predynastic Period.

However, theology is defined in the *Macquarie Concise Dictionary* as being a "Science dealing with God, his attributes and his relations to the universe; the science or study of divine things or religious truth divinity." (*Macquarie Concise Dictionary*, 2009, p. 1310) This definition does *not* include the requirement that theology must be based on a formal corpus, which the Texts are not. The Texts do, however, fall within this definition as they examine the attributes, and relations to the universe, of all of the gods in Egypt's pantheon. As such they are, for this period of Egyptian history, an embryonic component of religious theology.

The examination of the development of this theology is also critical to the understanding of Pharaoh's status from the late Predynastic Period to the middle stages of the Old Kingdom; that Pharaoh was a divinity who ruled absolutely on earth as "…supreme mortal…" and in heaven "as killer of the gods…with…supreme status in the Hereafter." (Davis, 1977, p. 165) As part of this discussion, Pharaoh's divine status – as reflected in the surviving iconography and imagery, and the political and religious ideology of Egypt during this period – will also be assessed.

While Pharaoh was divine, he was also responsible for the maintenance of order and justice in Egypt – Ma'at[5]; – these responsibilities included ensuring the Nile kept flowing, crops were planted and harvested and Egypt was safe from all her enemies, internal and external. (Mancini, 2004, p. 11)(Malek, 2000, p. 92) Pharaoh's divine status, and power, did not end at death; it continued in the afterlife to ensure Egypt's lasting stability. The Texts provided Pharaoh with the means to pass safely through, and survive, in the afterlife and therefore continue to protect Egypt (Malek, 2000, p. 103). An analysis of the concept of Ma'at – both as a goddess and a paradigm for "…order and equilibrium…" (David, 2002, p. 2) – in this period is therefore a necessary component of this assessment.

Consideration of the Texts' theological elements, and afterlife beliefs and funerary practices, will not be solely confined to analysing the status of Pharaoh in the period being examined; or why only Pharaoh – in the first instance Unas – was afforded the protection and benefits of the Texts in his tomb. Evaluation of the Texts in this paper will also include the evolution of, and what actually constituted, religious belief during Egypt's late Predynastic Period through the unification of Egypt to the latter stages of the Old Kingdom; and the evolution of Egyptian religious doctrine at the local and state level during this period. The discussion on these themes will also include Egypt's pantheon of gods.

The worship of Egypt's pantheon of gods began during the Predynastic Period with local deities worshipped in each town; "No god proclaimed his existence… the people…proclaimed it in their own way…their ways were many." (Dunand & Zivie-Coche, 2004, p. xii) Certain deities of the pantheon became prominent, resulting in the development of the major religious cult centres, including the solar cult at Heliopolis, the Memphite cult of Ptah and that of Hermopolis (Wilkinson, R., 2003, pp. 16-19). The Osiris cult, based at Abydos, was another competing religious centre. (Wilkinson, R., 2003, pp. 62-63) Multiple gods appear in the Texts, along with references reflecting each cult's central beliefs and political events. The battles for prominence and influence – religious and political – between Pharaoh and the priests in charge of the major cults will be examined in this paper.

[5] Depending on the reference being consulted Ma'at (the goddess) or ma'at (the ethical concept) is spelt variously as Maat or Ma'at; this paper will use Ma'at.

This paper will also examine the history of the discovery, publication and translation of the Texts; how royal funerary and mortuary practices evolved; the issue of whether Pharaoh was – or was not – viewed as divine and a god on earth; and the meaning of the Texts and what they provided for the deceased Pharaoh.

Discovery and Publication of the Texts

The initial discovery of the Texts by Gaston Maspero – in the pyramids of Unas, Teti, Pepi I, Merenre and Pepi II – occurred in 1880-1881. Maspero followed up the discovery, and excavation work, by publishing preliminary translations; the first release was those of Unas, in 1882. (Hornung, 1999, p. 2) Attempts at further translations of the Texts have continued intermittently since 1882 to the present day; with the edition authored by Kurt Sethe in 1908 still considered the benchmark edition. (Allen, 2005, p. 2) English translations of the Texts were published in 1952 by Samuel Mercer, 1969 by Raymond O Faulkner, and James P Allen in 2005.

As with the translations, further excavations and analysis of the pyramids where the Texts were discovered continued intermittently during the Twentieth Century. French archaeologists excavating at Saqqara during the 1920's, 1930's and 1950's discovered, and published translations of, Texts from the Sixth and Seventh Dynasty pyramids of Neith, Iput II and Wedjebetni and Ibi. Restoration work in the pyramids of Teti, Pepi I and Merenre has been ongoing since the late 1950's. (Allen, 2005, p. 2) This analysis – cross referenced with later copies of the Texts from the Middle and New Kingdom Periods discovered and published by archaeologists including the Egyptian Expedition of the Metropolitan Museum of Art in 1932 and William C Hayes in 1935 (Mercer, 2002, KL 147-162) – has progressively identified more utterances, substantially increasing the volume of known Texts.

Understanding the Pyramid Texts

How to translate, and interpret, the Texts has been debated by all who have worked on them since their discovery. Compounding this issue has been the parlous state of some of the tombs where Texts were found – damage in the chambers where Texts were inscribed has left fragments mixed with tomb rubble on the floors, and remaining columns on the walls either damaged or completely destroyed. (Allen, 2005, p. 2)(Mercer, 2002, KL 132-147). Work conducted by Jean-Philippe Lauer and Jean Sainte-Fare Garnot in 1951 on the Sixth-dynasty pyramids resulted in thousands of

extra Text fragments being identified. (Hornung, 1999, pp. 2-3) As a consequence of this damage it is unlikely that the full, original, complement of utterances has yet, or will be, identified.

Examination of the surviving Texts since their discovery has resulted in numerous opinions regarding the correct interpretation, and the original meaning of, the words when they were written millennia ago. Anthes (1954, p. 35) wrote one problem was "…complex ideas are condensed in an archaic and terse manner of expression." Producing an accurate translation from these passages was a "…weighty…" exercise. An incomplete understanding of Egyptian grammar from the period of the Texts and correct translation of individual, in some cases very ancient, hieroglyphs is a well-recognised problem. (Allen, 1954, p. 119)(Redford, 1973, p. 78)(Moore, 2006, p. 569)

How were the Texts read?

The Texts were ritual spells linking this world with that of the gods. Keeping this link foremost in their minds, the priests were meticulous regarding how the spells were recited, in what order, and by whom; only the "…lector priest…" was permitted to read the Texts during religious services. (Assmann, 2002, pp. 71-72) The Texts were also written in a "…orational style…" a style demanding the speaker recite in a "…strong regular rhythm." (Lichtheim, 2006, p. 30) The ritual, rhythmic, recitation of the Texts was aimed at ensuring the links between this world and the next remained unbroken. Thus how, and in what order, the Texts were intended to be recited in was of critical importance. (Assmann, 2002, pp. 71-72)

Complete understanding of the correct sequencing for, and recitation of, the Texts since their discovery has been complicated by how, and when, they were identified; while the Texts in Unas' tomb were largely complete (Allen, 2005, p. 2), those in other tombs were not. Some Texts have been identified from rubble fragments many decades after the tomb where they were inscribed was first opened. The sporadic identification of the Texts has left historians working on their translation and interpretation with incomplete data, meaning some of the assumptions made about the Texts are, at best, guesswork.

Some archaeologists and historians involved in examining the Texts have produced conflicting versions on how they should be read. Maspero and Sethe (Hornung, 1999, p. 4) read the utterances initially from the north wall of the sarcophagus chamber, as opposed to Schott and Piankoff who stated the spells at the entrance to the chamber

should be read first. Sethe also included a numbering system for the spells in his books; however Lichtheim (2006, p. 29) in discussing the numbering systems proposed by Sethe and other historians, highlights that the existence – or otherwise – of a logical order for the spells was, and remains, an extremely complex issue requiring ongoing work. Subsequent discoveries and analysis of the Texts since publication of Sethe's translations has identified major deficiencies with his numbering system. (Allen, 2005, pp. 2-4)

The Content of the Pyramid Texts

The Texts include Offering, Resurrection and personal protection utterances. (Allen, 2005, p. 1) The Offering Texts provided Pharaoh with the provisions – food, clothing and drink – he required in the afterlife; the Resurrection Texts the magic by which he rose from the dead and ascended to the gods. The personal protection Texts protected Pharaoh against any malevolent spirits he may encounter on his journey to the afterlife. (Allen, 2005, pp. 5-7)(De Trafford, 2007, p. 274)

The Text's purpose, which was more akin to a practical manual, than a "…doctrinal treatise…" (Tobin, 1989, p. 2) was to guide, protect and sustain the deceased pharaoh on his journey to the afterlife. The milestones of this journey for Pharaoh were his initial waking from death, ascending from the tomb to the sky and joining with the gods in the afterlife. (Lichtheim, 2006, p. 30) The hieroglyph passages that comprise the Texts were inscribed in vertical columns down the limestone walls of the interior chambers and passages of the pyramids. The green outline of the hieroglyphs was used to signify the "…hoped for regeneration of the deceased." (Hornung, 1999, p. 4)

While the Texts were probably recited at ritual and funerary services from the Predynastic period onwards, Unas' burial chamber provides the first known use of the Texts in a tomb. (Malek, 2000, p. 100) In Unas' pyramid, unlike those of his successors, the Texts were not carved into his sarcophagus and, possibly as a consequence of the limited space available in the interior chambers of his pyramid (Figure 3), were only placed in the burial and antechambers and passages linking these chambers. (Allen, 2005, pp. 15-16)

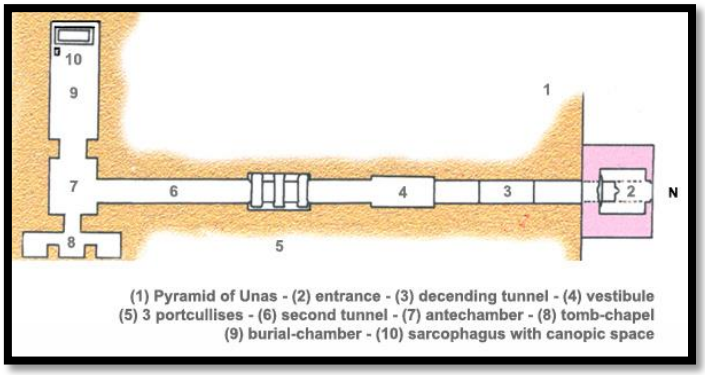


Figure 3 Map of interior layout of Pyramid of Unas,
Source: www.maat.sofiatopia.org/Pyramid_Texts_of_Unas
©Wim van den Dungen Antwerp, 2006 – 2013, Accessed 24 May 2013

The layout of the Texts in each pyramid generally followed the same pattern, with the Offering Ritual and Resurrection Ritual Texts inscribed along the north and south walls of the burial chamber. In Unas' burial chamber, again probably due to space limitations, these Texts extended beyond the burial chamber onto the east wall and the walls of the passage linking the burial and antechambers. More personal passages, provided to assist the deceased on their journey to the afterlife, were inscribed on the walls of the antechamber. (Allen, 2005, p. 16)

As the Texts likely existed, and were being used in the centuries preceding the Fifth Dynasty, it is probable that once writing, in the form of hieratic and hieroglyphs, was developed in Egypt a master record on papyrus scrolls was created. The development of writing was a major factor in the evolution of theological thought in Egypt's Early Dynastic Period; Ray (1986, p. 311) in discussing the origin of writing in Egypt examines the possibility of writing in Egypt being invented by the temple priests. While this is speculation, it is possible as the temples and the priests, particularly in the Early Dynastic Period, were closely linked with the ruling regime with the senior priests probably directly appointed by the Pharaoh. However writing evolved in Egypt, the sacred hymns, prayers and stories relating to Egypt's pantheon of gods could now be recorded, with hieroglyphs viewed by the Egyptians as "…words of god or divine speech." (Assmann, 2002, p. 71) Thus the Texts, previously only able to be passed to the next generation in oral form, could now be permanently recorded and used both as reference material and during sacred rituals. (Mercer, 1956, p. 52)(Dunand & Zivie-Coche, 2004, pp. xii-xiii)

The priests likely held a papyrus scroll copy of the Texts during religious services as it is improbable that they would have read the sacred texts "…from walls…" (Lapp in

Hays, 2012, p. 91) Also, the rituals of the funerary services were so important, with no divergence from the prescribed formats allowed, that only the "…lector priest…" or "…the bearer of the scroll…" was allowed to read the Texts. (Assmann, 2002, p. 71)

The necessity to ensure there was no divergence, or (more critically) errors, in the prescribed order of the Texts – so as to maintain the links between this world and the next (Assmann, 2002, p. 72) – would have been carried over into their carving inside the pyramids. A copy of the Texts chosen for inclusion in each pyramid would have been on hand to assist the craftsman coordinating the carving of the inscriptions. Given the Text's sacred nature, it is also possible priests were on hand to supervise the work. While every effort was probably made to ensure no errors occurred in the carving of the hieroglyphs, some mistakes were made by the craftsmen decorating the tomb. (Allen J. P., 2005, p. 5)

While certain Texts were found in all of the pyramids, each pyramid is unique in that different combinations of the utterances have been used for each burial. (Hornung, 1999, p. 5) However, the original version of the Texts was that used in the pyramid of Unas, this first corpus being the acknowledged primary version. Subsequent pharaoh's drew from, and expanded, this version for the Texts inscribed in their tombs. (Allen, 2005, p. 15)

The original composition date for the Texts is unknown (Mercer, 1956, p. 41); and the language used in the Texts is "…archaic…" (Anthes, 1954, p. 35) in nature when compared to contemporary language examples from the Fifth Dynasty; with it described by Hornung (1999, p. 5) as "…Old Egyptian…in a relatively antiquated form…' Supporting evidence confirming the pre-existence of the content of the Texts is in the remains of an offering list discovered in the temple of the pyramid of Sahure, second Pharaoh of the Fifth Dynasty. Ninety items from this list correspond exactly to a list of offerings in the Texts from Unas' pyramid. (Strudwick & Strudwick, 2011, KL 3743)

Why specific Texts were put in some tombs and not others is unknown; one possibility is changing trends in religious beliefs due to competition between the opposing theologies, such as Re's solar cult at Heliopolis and that of Osiris. This may have led to some Texts falling out of favour, being replaced, or rewritten to reflect the changes in religious doctrine. A specific example here is the efforts made over time by the

proponents of Osiris to include more Osiris-themed passages in the Texts, to the detriment of the solar cult. (Mercer, 2002, KL 106-114)

Alternatively, Texts may have been chosen by the deceased, or the priests may have chosen Texts they felt were appropriate for each individual Pharaoh. Another unknown element is the actual sequence in which the individual Texts were envisioned to be used by the priests during the funerary services, or by Pharaoh after the tomb was sealed; this issue has been the subject of debate since the Texts discovery. (Hornung, 1999, pp. 4-5)

The Texts as mortuary literature

The need to deal with death appropriately – including the disposal of the body and providing for the needs of the deceased in the afterlife – was one of the many evolving religious and cultural aspects of Old Kingdom Egypt. The ceremonial language used in the Texts was a significant component of these developing cultural elements. The various utterances that make up the Texts are a "…mortuary literature…" or "…ritual language…" (Assmann, 2005, p. 238); the aim of which was to magically equip the deceased pharaoh and ensure he lived in the afterlife in the style he was accustomed to.

The language of the Texts for this period utilised two forms, "…cultic recitation…" and "…written recording…" (Assmann, 2005, p. 237); recitation of the Texts was performed by the priests during the internment services and the carved inscriptions in the burial chambers provided the written record and eternal guidance for Pharaoh to utilise once the chamber was sealed. (Allen, 2005, p. 5)(De Trafford, 2007, p. 279) At the burial of Teti I (and subsequently in the tombs of Pepi II and Neith), to ensure the carved hieroglyphic utterances would "speak" for pharaoh, the word "recitation" was carved at the top of each vertical column of hieroglyphs and at the commencement of each prayer. (Allen, 2005, p. 65) Recitation of the Texts is likely also to have been intended as another means for dialogue between Pharaoh and the attendants preparing his burial as Pharaoh commenced his journey to the afterlife. (Rice, 2003, pp. 208-209)

The Fifth Dynasty – Pharaoh's power declines

Due to the passage of time, the reasons for the transition from the Fourth to the Fifth Dynasty are unlikely to be identified. Possible reasons for the Fourth Dynasty's demise include succession disputes, potentially ignited by the loss of political power of the regime; theological disputes over which of the various religious cults should take

precedence or simply that the dynasty died out due to a lack of male heirs. (Wenke, 2009, p. 278)(Aldred, 1988, p. 78)

Whatever the reason, the Fifth Dynasty took the throne, with Userkaf as the first Pharaoh. Nine pharaohs in total are believed to have ruled Egypt during this dynasty (Dodson, 2010, p. 62), with Egypt stable during this period. Trade with neighbouring countries in the Mediterranean, Nubia and Punt was initiated, with luxury items such as myrrh, ebony and gold highly sought after items. (Wenke, 2009, p. 279)

The Fourth-Dynasty Pharaohs, following on from the practices established after Egypt's unification, had ruled as absolute monarchs; Pharaoh *was* Egypt. All of the most senior government officials were royalty – power was kept in the family. (Wilkinson, T., 2010, pp. 79-80) Power, however, can corrupt; and the potential for family disputes to spread and impact on the governance of Egypt was a very real risk. (Frankfort, 1954, p. 31)

Userkaf – attempting, perhaps, to prevent family members from challenging his authority – removed them from the government bureaucracy (Wilkinson, T., 2010, pp. 79-80). While this decision took potential trouble-making members of the royal family out of active involvement in the day-to-day running of Egypt, it also was the beginning of the end for the absolute power exercised by the Fifth Dynasty Pharaohs, and ultimately the Old Kingdom. While Pharaoh, and his "…divine might…" to rule was not under direct threat as a consequence of Userkaf's decision, the concept of Egypt as a "…centralised state…" ruled and controlled *only* by royalty had been weakened. (Aldred, 1988, p. 78)

The nobility, seizing an opportunity for advancement as a consequence of Userkaf's decision, were another potential focus of trouble. Some of the noble families were either descendants of ruling families from earlier dynasties, or commoners who had married into the royal family. (Wenke, 2009, p. 279) Whatever their origins, it is likely some held aspirations of climbing above their current station in society to challenge Pharaoh.

The nobility grew in stature during the Fifth Dynasty, at the expense of Pharaoh's divine status and political power. Courtiers held in special favour by Pharaoh were now permitted to kiss his foot, as opposed to the custom during the reigns of Djoser and Cheops from the Fourth Dynasty where courtiers were only permitted to kiss the ground Pharaoh had walked on. (Aldred, 1988, p. 78) The ability of the elite to build ostentatious tombs during the Fifth Dynasty is another example of their (the nobles)

growth in power; only royalty during the Fourth Dynasty were able to build sumptuous funerary monuments. (Wenke, 2009, p. 279)

The role and growth in power of the priests of the major religious cults was another evolving cultural and political aspect of the Fifth Dynasty. Temples and cult sites had existed in Egypt from the Predynastic Period, with both community sites – small temples set up to worship local deities – and state-sponsored sites. The major sites were those sponsored by the ruling regime, such as the Temple of Horus at Hierakonpolis, with access to the main temple environs limited exclusively to the priests and Pharaoh; the Temple of Horus was surrounded by a large perimeter wall for this reason. (Wilkinson, T., 2000, p. 272)

Priests were appointed from the Early Dynastic Period to perform the rituals at the major temples and, as with the bureaucracy, were originally members of the royal family. (Frankfort, 1954, p. 31)(Wilkinson, T., 2000, p. 273) However, over time the temples, and the priests, became wealthy and powerful; exclusive priesthoods solely dedicated to serving the needs of the state-based cults were established by the Third Dynasty. The temples commanded considerable material wealth, both in land holdings and from offerings left at the temples by worshippers. (Wilkinson, T., 2000, pp. 273-274)(Rice, 2003, p. 199) This wealth and power meant the priests at the major cult centres were likely prepared to do anything to maintain what was a very lucrative lifestyle.

The ascendency of the cult of Ra during the Fourth Dynasty – formalised when Pharaoh Djedefra began calling himself the Son of Ra and characterised by the pyramids and the solar boats at Giza, and Pharaoh's name being encircled in a cartouche (Quirke, 2001, pp. 126-127) – was ultimately a triumph for the priests and a loss for Pharaoh. Djedefra, with this decision, was no longer supreme among the gods; he was merely one of a group of gods surrounding Ra. Pharaoh's divine status was reduced, while the power of the priests – particularly those serving at the temples dedicated to Ra – was enhanced. (Wilkinson, T., 2010, p. 79)

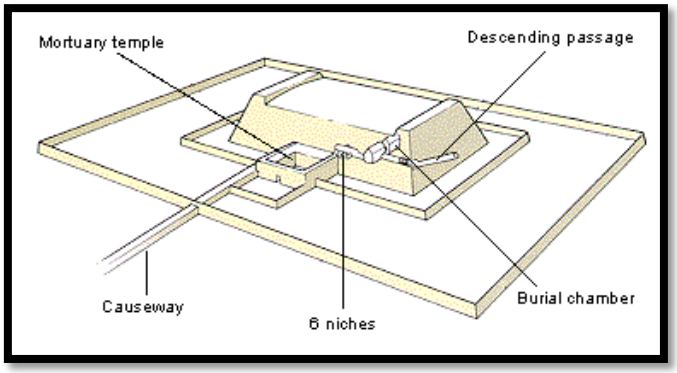


Figure 4 Mastaba Tomb of Shepseskaf
Source: www.ancient-egypt.org from Lehner, Complete Pyramids, p. 139
Accessed 15 Jun 2013

Shepseskaf, last Pharaoh of the Fourth Dynasty, (Dodson & Hilton, 2010, p. 50), in a possible attempt to re-assert his divine power, may have fought back against the priests of Ra. (Wenke, 2009, p. 278) Wenke discusses surviving records alluding to possible dynastic tensions in the ruling family, as well as ongoing concerns with regard to the religious philosophy underpinning the state. Shepseskaf did not associate himself with Ra in any of his formal names or titles, and his burial monument – located at Saqqara (Tyldesley, 2009, pp. 46-47) – was not a pyramid, but one favoured by his predecessors before the advent of Ra – a mastaba (Figure 4). (David, 1982, pp. 50-51)(Quirke, 2001, p. 126)

Whether Shepseskaf did actually fight back against the priests is unknown, however any attempt by Shepseskaf to reduce the power of the priests would have been in vain. The diminishing of Pharaoh's power – from that existing at the time of Egypt's unification when "…the concept of the Kingship and of the godhead…" was brought "…into a precise conjunction." and the "…king was god because he was king." (Rice, 1997, pp. 86-87) – had gone beyond the point of no return.

Burial of a Pharaoh

From the Predynastic Period the concept of an afterlife for Pharaoh was evolving with the tomb not merely being the site where his body was placed for eternity – it was also where Pharaoh could continue to live, in his accustomed lifestyle, after death. All that Pharaoh needed in the afterlife was placed in the tomb – food, drink, furniture and other household goods – Pharaoh would want for nothing. Early tombs were designed to replicate the palace where Pharaoh had lived; he would be at home. (Wilkinson, T., 2000, p. 255) Early examples of these tombs exist from the Naqada III period. A possible royal tomb from this period – Tomb U-j located at Umm el-Qaab at Abydos

and consisting of 12 rooms – is one such surviving example. (Dodson & Ikram, 2008, pp. 134-135)



Figure 5 Mastaba at Saqqara
Source: ©Anne-Marie Pope 1 April 2013

The royal tombs evolved during the Early Dynastic Period into mastabas (Figure 5); these were initially underground burials covered with a mound, the tombs then developing over time into a structure comprising underground chambers with stepped brick superstructures. The purpose of the mound or superstructure was possibly to represent the "Island of Creation". (David, 1982, pp. 54-55) The Island of Creation was the location in Egyptian mythology where the gods first settled and life was created, and the inclusion of a mound of some description over the tomb was a potent symbol of "…rebirth and resurrection." (Wilkinson, T., 2000, p. 256)

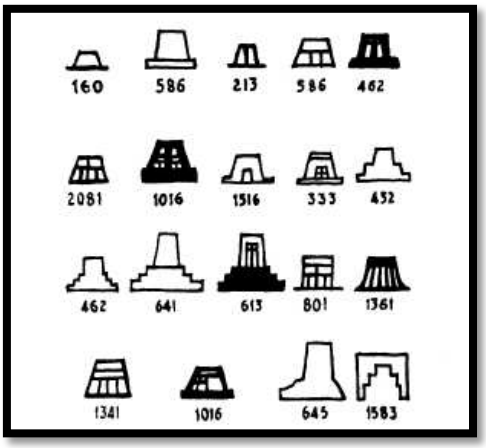


Figure 6 Mastaba shaped hieroglyph signs from the Pyramid Texts
Source: Section of Figure 1 from Badawy, 1956, p. 181
Accessed 31 Jan 2013

Resurrection of the deceased pharaoh was necessary to enable him, according to PT 1123a, to "…go forth to the sky …" (Allen, 1989, p. 1), The tomb, therefore, was the

launching point from which Pharaoh would journey to the stars and the shape of the tomb – in this instance a mastaba with a stepped superstructure leading skywards – was a necessary component to ensure Pharaoh could successfully leave the tomb. The physical design of a mastaba is also mirrored in the hieroglyph sign in the Texts for the phrase "to ascend" – this sign is shaped like a mastaba (Figure 6). (Badawy, 1956, p. 181 & 183) The mastaba design evolved in the Third Dynasty into what became the Step Pyramid (Figure 7) (Dodson & Ikram, 2008, pp. 142-144); the Pyramid Age had arrived.



Figure 7 Step Pyramid
Source: ©Anne-Marie Pope 1 April 2013

The power and strength embodied in the early period of the Fourth Dynasty was characterised by the building of the Giza plateau pyramids (Figure 8) and the Bent and Red pyramids at Dahshur. (Dodson & Hilton, 2010, p. 50) The straight sides of the later pyramids from this era, moving away from the stepped superstructure of earlier monuments, is a probable reflection of the change in the precedence of the religious cults – from astral to solar - fostered by Pharaoh at a state level. The presence of a celestial cult in the Early Dynastic Period is attested in the Texts; PT 148 (Allen, 2005, p. 31) describes Unas ascending to the stars, stating that he will be the companion of the "…star-god…" The astral deities – known as the "Imperishable Ones" represented the northern stars, which were visible in Egypt. Richard Wilkinson (2003, pp. 90-91) suggests that these stars may have represented the concept of "…eternal survival." hence the desire of Pharaoh's from the Early Dynastic Period to join with the star gods.

Quirke (2001, pp. 119-121), in examining the ascendency of the solar cult of Ra, suggests that the Step Pyramid was possibly the first significant monument in Egypt

reflecting this change in religious philosophy. The Step Pyramid linked for the first time a "…single earthly king with a single power in heaven, the sun." This change in religious philosophy, and the ascendency of Ra, was reflected in the Fourth-Dynasty change in pyramid design. Pharaoh would ascend – not via stairs as per the shape of a mastaba – but instead via a ramp generated from the rays of the sun, with the straight sides of the pyramids providing the base for the solar ramp. (Dodson & Ikram, 2008, p. 148)



Figure 8 Pyramids at Giza Source: ©Anne-Marie Pope 1 April 2013

Whatever the reason for the change in pyramid design, the early Fourth Dynasty Pharaoh's – Sneferu, Khufu and Khafra – as absolute rulers and with seemingly unlimited resources at their disposal, ordered the construction of these mighty edifices. (Wilkinson, T., 2010, pp. 61-65 & 75) The pyramids met all of the requirements for Egypt's rulers; they were large, magnificent, and corresponded with the opulence of their life before death. The pyramids became the focus, and a visible symbol of, the mortuary cult for each Pharaoh, (Quirke, 2001, p. 122); their design assuring Pharaoh an easy journey to the stars.

The Giza pyramids are an enduring, symbol of the power the Fourth Dynasty pharaohs had at their disposal. However, the drain on national resources – including manpower, materials and administrative burdens – fatally weakened the regime. (Wilkinson, T., 2010, p. 75) The Fifth Dynasty Pharaoh's, while following the traditions of their predecessors in building pyramids, knew from the time of Unas of their inability to command the level of political power and resources necessary to build these massive monuments.

The Fifth-Dynasty monuments included large sun temples reflecting the regime's focus on the solar cult, as exemplified in the name of the sun temple of Pharaoh Sahura: "Sekhetra – field of Ra" (Quirke, 2001, p. 128). These temples were much more modest structures than those that survive at Giza. (Dodson & Hilton, 2010, p. 62)(Aldred, 1988, p. 78) The inclusion of the Texts in Unas' pyramid may have been employed as an alternative solution to a larger funerary monument to assist him to the afterlife. While the physical structure of his pyramid was far less impressive and robust than those of the early Fourth Dynasty, the Texts ensured Unas would still join the gods.

Theology, religion and the Pyramid Texts

The Texts represent the first recorded version of religious and mortuary beliefs from Egypt's Predynastic and Early Dynastic Periods; they are also embryonic components of the evolution of religious theology during this period. The term "theology" can arguably be used to solely imply detailed thinking or critiquing of sacred writings, such as the Bible or the Koran. Depending on the context in which the term "theology" is used it could also be used in other connotations including (but not limited to) divinity, doctrine, mysticism and spirituality. However theology, in the context of religious beliefs extant during this period of Egyptian history, includes far broader meanings and themes than being simply focused on a corpus of sacred writings.

As previously mentioned, theology has been variously defined as a "Science dealing with God, his attributes and relations to the universe…" and "…the study of divine things or religious truth or divinity." (*Macquarie Concise Dictionary*, 2009, p. 1310). Theology has also been defined as "…that which describes a god (or gods) and his (or their) actions." (Smith, 1952, p. 137); and by Carus (1902, pp. 561-562) as a "…science, the roots of which lie…in philosophy…history…ethics…" and "…religious literature."

None of these definitions include the caveat that theology is, or *must*, be based on a formal corpus such as the Bible or the Koran; but that instead theology is a *mechanism* by which matters involving God, gods and/or divine things can be studied and examined. Egyptians during the Early Dynastic Period and Old Kingdom believed the divine entities in Egypt's pantheon could, and did, influence events in the universe and on earth; therefore it was necessary to understand the world of the gods and their impact on humankind. (Te Velde, 1995, p. 1731) This theology, while not based on a formal

corpus of sacred writings, was an evolving creed that aimed to understand and examine the attributes of, and the relations to, the universe of all of the gods in Egypt's pantheon.

Assmann (2008, pp. 12-19), discusses the "…implicit theology…" of religion in Ancient Egypt, where for Egyptians the contentment of the gods was all-important, and religion comprised three dimensions – the "…cultic or politic, the cosmic and the linguistic." The cultic/politic component was each settlement, with all residents worshipping the local deity; the cosmic component, that governing order and harmony – Ma'at – as opposed to chaos; and the linguistic component, that referring to sacred texts and the magical power inherent when the texts were recited. This theology is *not* a formal corpus, but it *was* a mechanism by which the ancient Egyptians sought to understand their world and enable them to satisfy the gods and avoid chaos.

The term "religion", as with "theology", is a phrase with multiple definitions and different themes and meanings; including that religion is a "…belief in a supreme or supernatural power or powers thought to control the universe…", and a "…formalised system in which that belief has been embodied…" (*Macquarie Concise Dictionary*, 2009, p. 1063) The human element of religion is described as humans recognising "…a controlling superhuman power entitled to obedience, reverence and worship." these concepts recognised by the Egyptians in their worship of local and state deities. While we only know that the Egyptians had gods because of the surviving records and myths, from the Predynastic Period onwards Egyptians believed the gods existed. (Dunand & Zivie-Coche, 2004, pp. 5-6) These divinities were integral entities in the universe of the next world as defined in the Creation myths, and were part of daily life for all Egyptians.

As with the formal definitions of theology, these definitions of religion do not include the caveat that religion must be based on a formal corpus of sacred writings; or that only one god, and the teachings of that god, can be worshipped and followed. (Frankfort, 1954, p. 1) The religion of Ancient Egypt that evolved from the Predynastic Period through to the Old Kingdom was one such creed, described by Morenz in Assmann (2001, p. ix) as "…not a religion of the book…" but a traditional, cult based, belief system. This cult based system recognised all of the gods in Egypt's pantheon, and succeeded without relying on "…one basic truth." (Frankfort, 1954, p. 1), or message, as is the case with Islam, Christianity and Judaism.

Predynastic Egypt – birth of worship and ritual activity

Very little physical evidence relating to religious activity – such as temples or sacred shrines – or beliefs, other than those related to funerary activities, has survived from Egypt's Predynastic Period, exacerbating the problems for scholars attempting to tease out the story of this part of Egypt's social history during the fourth millennium B.C. (Wenke, 2009, p. 80) Bard (1992, p. 17) states that the lack of archaeological evidence relating to shrines indicates that the population during the Predynastic and Early Dynastic Periods focused their material and construction activities on cemeteries, not temples. Absence of evidence, however, is not evidence of absence of beliefs or ritual activity. It is likely that shrines did exist, built of easily obtained materials including reeds, mats and bricks; with these used for sacred activities unrelated to funerary activities. (Dunand & Zivie-Coche, 2004, p. 72) These structures, and any artefacts, have not survived to be assessed by archaeologists.

It is likely, however, that the population of Egypt – as with other prehistoric peoples – would have been highly aware, and cautious, of the power of the natural world around them. (Wilkinson, R., 2003, p. 12) This power could sustain life by providing good harvests, take life away with failed harvests in times of drought, or protect individuals from illness and accidents. The earliest divine entities worshipped in Egypt were probably those identified as having some controlling power over the forces of nature. (Breasted, 2011, p. 1)(Wilkinson, R., 2003, p. 15)

During the Naqada I and II periods, c. 4000-3200 B.C. (Wenke, 2009, p. 196) the climate was wetter than during the later Dynastic Period and storms were viewed as "…blessed, yet dangerous…" (Wainwright, 1963, p. 14 & 19) One of the storm gods whom the population would have worshipped to ensure the storms remained blessed, not dangerous, was Min; the cult of Min is thought to have originated during this wet phase of Egyptian history. In keeping with this element of his divine persona, Min's symbol was a "…many-pointed weapon…the thunderbolt." The bull was also linked with the cult of Min, with the bull striding through the mountains – the home of the storm gods. (Wainwright, 1963, p. 14)



Figure 9 Boat with animals and god Min at Kanais Temple
Source: www.eastern-desert.com/kanais_temple
Accessed 16 Jul 13

Min was also worshipped as a fertility god, with one of the earliest depictions of Min in the characteristic 'ithyphallic' pose (one arm raised with the other holding his erect phallus) that in a petroglyph in the temple of Kanais in the Eastern Desert. (Figure 9) (Wilkinson, R., 2003, pp. 191-192) While depictions of Min and his symbols have been found at Kanais, and also on the Scorpion mace head discovered at Hierakonpolis (Wainwright, 1963, pp. 17-18), the major cult site for Min was at Coptus, an ancient town located near Wadi Hammamat (Figure 10). (Hornblower, 1946, p. 115) Other locations from this period evolved similarly into cult sites, linking gods with individual towns.



Figure 10 Proposed reconstruction of Temple at Coptus
Source: www.digitalegypt.ucl.ac.uk/koptus
Accessed 16 Jul 2013

As well as Coptus, cult sites emerged at Hierakonpolis – associated with Horus as "…the city of the Falcon" – and Nubt, associated with Set (Seth). (Rice, 2003, p. 31) All three of these sites are evidence of early significant ritual activity, the growth of cults and use of sacred sites during the Predynastic Period. The temples at the larger sites were made of similar materials to the smaller temples found in local villages –

including wood, mud and reeds – with the Temple of Min at Coptus possibly looking like the reconstruction in Figure 10.

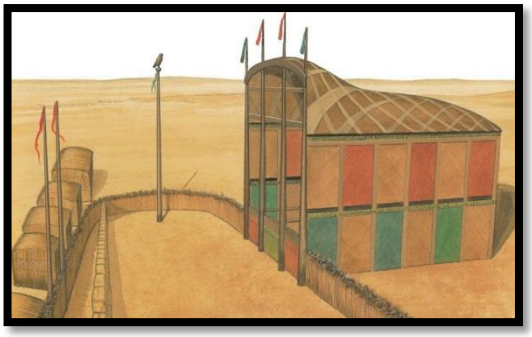


Figure 11 Temple at Hierakonpolis
Source: www.egypt.net.in_ancient-egypt-temples
Accessed 15 Jul 2013



Figure 12 Remains of temple perimeter trench at Hierakonpolis
Image source: ©Nekhen News, Vol 20, 2008, p. 7, from www.emhotep,net
Accessed 17 Jul 2013

The temple at Hierakonpolis, as envisaged in Figure 11, was also probably constructed out of similar materials. During the Naqada II C-D period (c. 3650-3300 B.C.) the original perimeter wall to the temple (comprising a wood posts and lattice fencing set in a deep trench) was replaced with a more permanent structure of mud brick and stone; the remains of which are seen in Figure 12. (Wengrow, 2006, pp. 80-81) A "…ritual foundation…" of clean sand was also laid under the mud floor of the structure. This "High Sand" is thought to have been a symbolic representation of the primeval mound that arose out of the waters at the time of Creation. (Rickie, 1935 in Hikade, 2011, pp. 95-96) Additional archaeological evidence that the site had been used for ritual activities is in the ivory and stone votive objects left by worshippers. (Bussman, 2011, p. 760)

Aside from the major cult/temple sites, local deities were worshipped in every village across Egypt. "An Egyptian city was always the city of a deity." (Assmann, 2001, pp. 19-20) Personal worship was focused towards the deity of their home village, inextricably linking home with religious and ritual activity.

Worship of these deities was conducted in small temples where the representations of the god – statues and symbols – would have been kept in shrines at the centre of the structure. The very early temples that would have been found in the villages were likely simple structures made of the same materials as the huts in the villages, but the temple would have been larger than the huts to accommodate the representations of the god. (David, 2002, pp. 50-51)(Dunand & Zivie-Coche, 2004, p. 72) These temples did not stand in isolation but were surrounded by the shops, dwellings and other buildings

making up each village; the local deity was worshipped in a sacred area, but daily life went on around the temple. (Rice, 2003, p. 78)

The sacred objects and geographical features worshipped by the Egyptians of the Predynastic period took many forms – including animals, objects such as shields or sceptres, trees, stones and statues. Petrie (2012, pp. 20-21 & 27) noted that animals that were being worshipped all "…had qualities for which they were noted…" and it was these superior qualities that were being honoured. These superior qualities engendered "…religious significance for the Egyptians." Anything other than human – as with animals – was possibly viewed by the Egyptians as "…superhuman…" (Frankfort, 1954, pp. 10-11) Gods also began to be depicted in anthropomorphic forms – human bodies with animal heads. (Watterson, 1984, pp. 32-33)

The original reasons why deities were depicted in this manner are unlikely to ever be known. Interpretation of anthropomorphic artefacts from the Predynastic Period, and their origins, has been the subject of vigorous debate between historians. (Wilkinson, R., 2003, p. 15)(Dunand & Zivie-Coche, 2004, p. 17) Toby Wilkinson (2003, pp. 139-141) argues that the people of Predynastic Egypt would invoke magical strength by wearing items related to the animal they were hunting. This concept – the mix of animal and human elements – is taken further in a rock drawing from Wadi Umm Salam; the human figure shown with a bull is wearing a headdress with two tall plumes. This headdress during the Dynastic Period was viewed as a mark of divinity: the Predynastic figure, one of the earliest identified divine anthropomorphic drawings, is probably a prehistoric image of a god assisting cattle herders.

Another possible reason is that the ancient Egyptians viewed differences between humans and animals as "…not absolute but…relative…" so, as both were living creatures, deities could be depicted as either, or a combination of both. (Te Velde, 1980, p. 79) Whatever the reason, as time progressed through to the Early Dynastic Period, gods were regularly depicted as animals, humans and beings with human bodies and animal heads.

Evolution of Egypt's pantheon of gods

The hundreds of gods in Egypt's pantheon evolved from local deities worshipped in villages throughout Egypt. The influence of some of the local gods expanded to regional status (such as Horus at Hierakonpolis) then, after unification, to national status. One

very early example of a deity that moved from local to national importance is the goddess Neith, whose cult centre was based at Sais in the Nile delta, but who became a major deity as early as Dynasty I. (Hornung, 1996, pp. 70-72)

The deities in Egypt's pantheon can be grouped into three categories – local, personal and universal gods. Local deities, as already discussed, were those linked with a particular locality. Universal gods were those recognised at a national level, worshipped at the major cult centres such as Heliopolis. (Watterson, 1984, pp. 35-36) Personal gods – which could be an object or a deity – were those chosen by an individual to be their unique focus for veneration. While individuals in Egypt may have had their own "personal" deity to worship, the worship of the local and universal deities was not confined purely to the upper echelons of society; all of the gods in Egypt's pantheon were worshipped by *all* Egyptians. (Morenz, 1979, p. 56)

Creation Mythology and the Birth of the Gods

According to the ancient Egyptians before Creation nothing existed except the black, still waters of Nun; within these waters there was a single egg. When that egg cracked, life emerged and a mound ascended out of the waters. Sitting on the mound was the god Atum, who now set about creating a living, dynamic world of gods, cities and people. (Tyldesley, 2011, p. 37) Atum's emergence, and "…self-generation…" was thus an act of "…world generation." (Naydler, 1996, pp. 37 & 40-41) After ascending out of the egg and the waters of Nun, Atum began spawning gods – with the first being Shu and Tefnut followed by Geb, Nut, Osiris, Isis, Seth and Nephthys. (Figure 13) (Wilkinson, R., 2003, pp. 17-18)

This story, however, is not as clear as it seems with differing versions of the Creation – also known as "The First Occasion" (Dunand & Zivie-Coche, 2004, p. 52) – how man emerged onto the earth and the subsequent mythology of Egypt's pantheon developing over time. Several schools of theological thought also evolved, including the Heliopolitan, Hermopolitan and Memphis Theologies. Each of these schools had different gods identified as the "…primary source of existence." (Frankfort, 1954, p. 18) In the Memphis Theology Ptah was responsible for creation, brought about by the "…the spoken word…" of the god. The sun-god was responsible for creation in the Heliopolitan Theology and the lunar god Thoth in the Hermopolitan Theology. (Naydler, 1996, p. 35 & 46)

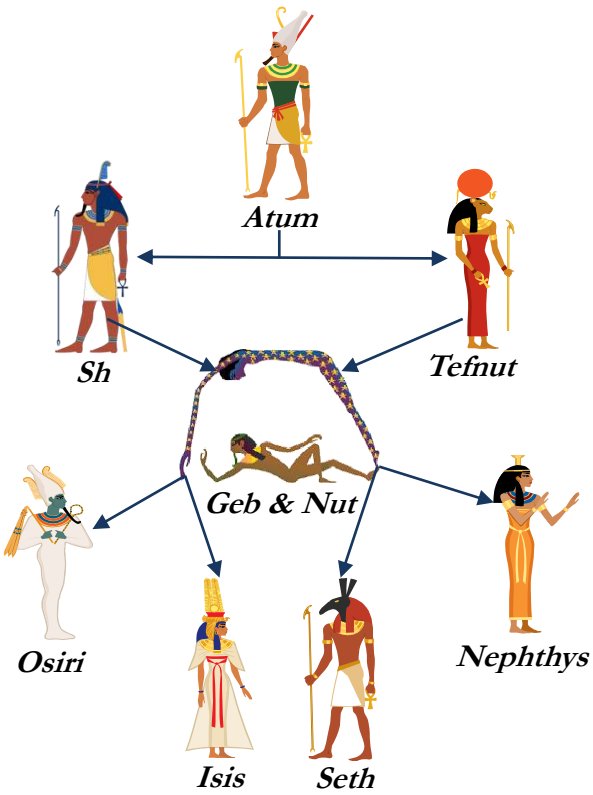


Figure 13 Heliopolitan Ennead Genealogy
Source: Adapted from Wilkinson, R.H., 2003, p. 18

Heliopolitan Theology – The Solar Cult and the God Re

The Creation myth of the Solar Cult of Heliopolis has already been described, with the first nine gods (Figure 13) becoming the Ennead or "…The Nine of Heliopolis." (Wenke, 2009, p. 266) However, a solar cult is thought to have existed by at least the late Predynastic Period. (Tyldesley, 2011, pp. 38-39) Possible evidence of solar worship has been found in grave goods from this period in the shape of funerary barques – the funerary barques may have been intended to allow the deceased to join the sun god in the solar barque. The symbol of the cult at this period was a circle with a central spot. (David, 1980, p. 33)

While the god Atum is identified in some versions of Heliopolitan Creation mythology as the divine entity which first emerged on the primeval mound, the god Re – the sun god – is identified in other versions as the first divine entity to emerge. (Wilkinson, R., 2003, pp. 206-207) One version of the Creation myth states that after Atum appeared on the primeval mound and while the world was still dark, a "…bird of light…" appeared and that bird became the god Re. (Naydler, 1996, pp. 38-39) The dawning of the sun every morning was seen by the Egyptians as a re-enactment of the first appearance of light in the world.

As with other divine entities from Egypt's pantheon, Atum and Re were seen both as separate and merged entities – reflecting the rather fluid manner with which Egyptians viewed the divinities they worshipped. (Naydler, 1996, p. 40) Merging of entities did not mean that attributes linked with the individual god were lost after the entities merged; these attributes became part of the linked divinity. With respect to the sun-god, in this period of Egyptian history, as well as the god being known as Atum, Re and Atum-Re, the sun-god was also identified as Khepri-Re-Atum. Khepri (who was normally represented as a beetle and identified as "…the one who comes into being…") represented the dawning of the sun, Re the sun at noon and Atum the sun setting at the end of the day. (Tyldesley, 2011, p. 42)(Dunand & Zivie-Coche, 2004, p. 27)

Memphis Theology – Thought and Expression

The evidence for the existence of the Memphis Theology is the surviving text on the Shabaka Stone, held in the British Museum. The stone dates from the Twenty-Sixth Dynasty, but is believed to be a copy of a much older document (possibly from the First Dynasty – Finnestad, 1976, p. 83) and it describes an alternative view of the Creation. (Wilkinson, R., 2003, pp. 18-19) This text diverges from the creation myth already described in that the god Ptah – the Creator God (Figure 14) – preceded Atum and was thus the creator of "…the life of the gods" and all life on earth. (Finnestad, 1976, pp. 82-83) Ptah created via thought and the spoken word, with Atum procreated from Ptah's "…heart and tongue…" (Tyldesley, 2011, pp. 66-67) The centre of intellect in the human body, according to the ancient Egyptians of this period was the heart, not the brain, hence the reference to Atum being created by thought from the heart.

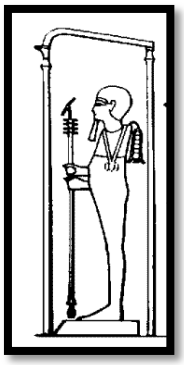


Figure 14 Ptah
Source: Section of image from Egyptian Mysteries, p. 10, Thames & Hudson
Accessed from www.kheper.net 28 Jul 2013

Hermopolitan Theology – Hidden power

While the Heliopolitan Theology was a solar cult, the Hermopolitan Theology was a lunar cult. The city of Hermopolis was the cult centre for Thoth, a deity identified as a moon god. (Naydler, 1996, p. 46 & 49) Thoth was also seen as a "…creator…" working through thought and the "…power of productive speech." (Boylan, 1922, p. 122) Thoth was an ancient deity, with his ibis standard appearing on predynastic palettes, and he appears repeatedly in the Texts. (Wilkinson, R., 2003, p. 215) PT 150 (Allen, 2005, p. 33) has Thoth announcing "…to the gods of the West…this Unas has come to you…" In the Hermopolitan version of the Creation Myth Thoth – not Atum – is the god emerging from the waters of Nun to bring forth life.

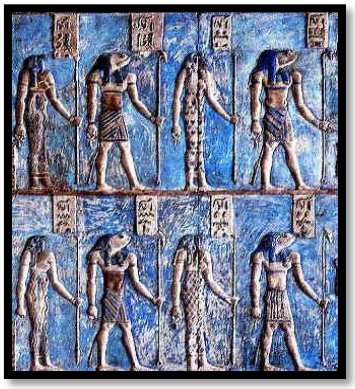


Figure 15 The Ogdoad.
Source: ©2013 www.Land_of_Pyramids.org
Accessed 28 Jul 2013

Creation was then engendered by the Ogdoad (Figure 15), four pairs (each male and female) of primordial divine entities. (Dunand, 2004, pp. 49-50) The four pairs were Nun and Naunet (primeval water), Heh and Hauhet (eternity), Kek and Kauket (darkness), and Amun and Amaunet (that which is hidden). Each of the pairs of divine entities were initially inert, but they all had the capability to create life. Once life had been created – in the form of the sun god – the Ogdoad died, passing to the next world where they directed the rising and setting of the sun and the flow of the Nile. (Tyldesley, 2011, p. 56) The age of this myth is unknown, but possibly has its antecedents in the Early Dynastic Period. (Wilkinson, R., 2003, pp. 16-17)(Naydler, 1996, pp. 50-51)

Ma'at

In the mythology of Creation in ancient Egypt, at the same time as the world was created after the mound emerged out of the primeval waters of Nun, the necessity to

immediately establish order and stability in the world was recognised. (Bleeker, 1964, p. 78) Ma'at, the concept of "…justice and cosmic order…" and "…truth and right" was born. (Wilkinson, R., 2003, pp. 150-152) As ma'at was established at the time of creation, the notion of justice and world order that was personified in ma'at was an eternal concept which did not change – as it was at the beginning, so it would remain for all time. (Tobin, 1989, p. 8)(Dunand & Zivie-Coche, 2004, p. 54) All Egyptians – from Pharaoh down to the peasants in the fields – were expected to "…act and live in accordance with…" the principles espoused by ma'at so "…all would be well for the individual, community, state and the universe." (Tobin, 1989, p. 11) Individuals living according to the ideals of Ma'at could expect to live well, and with prosperity, both in this world and the next. (Mancini, 2004, p. 3)

As well as the concept of ma'at representing the ethical concepts of justice and world order, ma'at was also personified as a female goddess. This goddess – Ma'at – was the daughter of the sun god, variously identified as Re, Atum or Atum-Re. (Naydler, 1996, pp. 92-93)(Teeter in Wenke, 2009, pp. 272-273) Ma'at, as the image of order, was always depicted as being next to the sun-god to ensure the continuance of that order. As the goddess also representing justice, Ma'at appears in the Texts as providing judgement on the right of the king to ascend the throne. (Wilkinson, R., 2003, p. 150) While ma'at was both a concept and a goddess, the Egyptian view was there was no difference between the two; both were equally valid, and important, to the stability of Egypt. (Tobin, 1989, p. 84) Karenga (2006, pp. 5-6) states that Ma'at was a "…fundamental, pervasive and enduring…" facet of the ancient Egyptian culture, and was at the very foundation of the worldview of the Egyptians.

The need to pacify the gods and ensure the continuance of ma'at was recognised by all Egyptians of this period, with the lead being taken by Pharaoh. Pharaoh was the intermediary between all Egyptians and the gods; only Pharaoh – via the construction of temples, regular sacrifices, the offerings of devotions and food and controlling Egypt's enemies – could ensure the gods were pacified and guarantee Egypt's stability and prosperity. (Gahlin, 2002, p. 80) The offering of a figure of Ma'at during religious ceremonies to the gods was one of the means by which Pharaoh demonstrated his recognition of "…the divine order." (Bleeker, 1964, p. 79) Offering a figure of Ma'at to the sun by Pharaoh also allowed the energy from the solar deity to "…circulate forever." (Mancini, 2004, p. 5) Ma'at constituted a fundamental component, and

primary goal, of Egyptian religion at this time; which was to frustrate the "…forces of chaos, disorder and death…" (Wenke, 2009, pp.264-265)

The cult of Osiris

According to Egyptian mythology, the kingship was established at the time of creation, along with the establishment of order and justice in the form of ma'at – the two concepts inextricably linked together from the start. The first Pharaoh of Egypt, according to the Creation myths, was Re. (Wilkinson, R., 2003, pp. 207-208).

Re's successor was Osiris, with the story of his rule being a very human story involving love and murder; but as with all other myths, multiple versions exist. The commonly accepted elements of the myth are that Osiris ruled with his sister-wife Isis and was later murdered by his brother Seth. After his murder, Isis recovered Osiris' body, resurrected him, impregnated herself and subsequently gave birth to Horus. (Wenke, 2009, p. 266) After his resurrection, Osiris left the earth to became the lord "…of the underworld." or the *Duat.* (O'Connor, 2011, pp. 31-32)

It is as lord of the *Duat*, and the symbol of rebirth and regeneration, that Osiris, and his cult, became very important elements of the developing Egyptian theology from this period. As a symbol of rebirth, Osiris is linked with the annual Nile flood and the subsequent crops that provide food for the people of Egypt; Osiris as the *Duat* is also linked with the safe passage of the sun-god – and, by default, all deceased Egyptians – through each night to rise again each dawn. The Osiris myths therefore are an important component of the sun-god cosmogony of the Heliopolitan theology. (O'Connor, 2011, pp. 38-39)

The incorporation of Osiris into the Heliopolitan theology may have been as a result of the growing power of Osiris' cult during the Old Kingdom. The priests of Re, acknowledging the strength of the cult and, perhaps, working on the principal that it was better to work with someone than against them, drew the Osiris cult into the Heliopolitan theology. (Tyldesley, 2011, p. 110)

Horus and Seth

The last significant segment in the story of Osiris after he became lord of the *Duat* is that of Horus and Seth. After being hidden by his mother Isis until he grew to manhood, with Isis fearful that Seth would murder Horus as he had murdered Osiris, Horus stepped up to claim from Seth his inheritance – the Throne of Egypt. (Watterson, 1984,

pp. 100-102) After many bloody battles between Horus and Seth for the throne, the contest was ultimately decided by Re, who chose Horus as the rightful heir. (Dunand & Zivie-Coche, 2004, p. 39)

Both Horus and Seth were worshipped from the Predynastic Period, with representations of falcons on the Narmer Palate probably those of Horus, and Seth known from an early representation – in ivory – from the Naqada I period, the Scorpion mace head and on the labels in Figure 17. (Wilkinson, R., 2003, p. 197-200) The cult centre for Horus was Hierakonpolis, with the cult of Horus becoming prominent during the Predynastic Period; the "Horus Name" being one of Pharaoh's official names. The linking of Horus with Pharaoh may have led to Hierakonpolis evolving from a cult centre to a site of major political importance during the Predynastic Period. (Wilkinson, T., 2000, pp. 286-287) The standard image of the Horus Name from the Predynastic and Early Dynastic Periods was that in the *serekh* – a frame in which the Horus Name was carved at the top, with a depiction of a palace facade at the bottom and a Horus Hawk sitting on the top of the frame. (Figure 16) (Watterson, 1984, pp. 99-101)

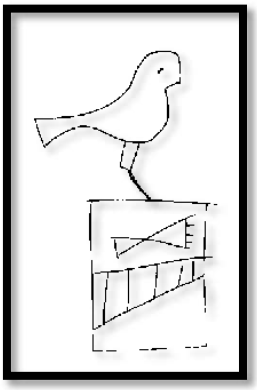


Figure 16 Serekh of Narmer, Dynasty I, incised on potter from Arad,
Source: Fisher, J., after Amirah, J., Israel Exploration Journal, 24 (1974), Fig. 1.1,
www.penn.museum/sites/Canaan/EarlyBronzeAge

Horus was also recognised as the god representing Upper Egypt. Horus was therefore, from a very early date, inextricably linked with Pharaoh and the kingship of Egypt. The divine rule of the gods over Egypt was transmitted through Horus (as the son of Osiris), to Pharaoh, and into the human realm. (O'Connor, 2011, p. 39)

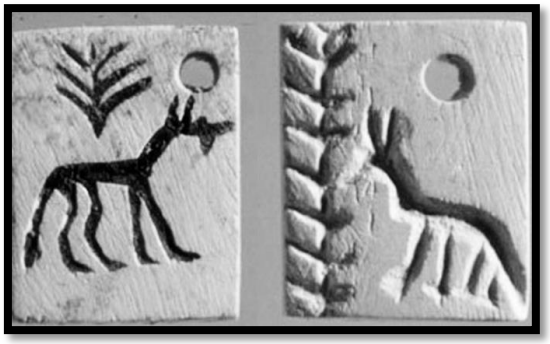


Figure 17 Labels with images of Seth, tomb of King Scorpion, Abydos, c. 3200 BCE
Image source: www.dainst.org/tombU-j_DAI ©,
in *Seth, God of Confusion*, Te Velde, H., p. 61 on www.joanannlansberry.com

The cult of Seth (Figure 17), at this time was an important one with Seth linked with thunderstorms, turbulence and the desert; conversely Seth also served as "…the aggressive form of cosmic order, repelling threatening chaotic…" cosmic forces. (O'Connor, 2011, p. 39) The link with the desert, with that part of Egypt referred to as the "…Red Land…" led to Seth also being known as the "Red God". (Watterson, 1984, pp. 114-115) Seth was viewed as a god of strength, and is cited frequently in the Texts. In PT 158, one of the spells carved into the antechamber of Unas' pyramid to help Unas leave his burial chamber, Seth – in his persona of the storm god – is present to help Unas and "…bear…" him from the chamber. (Allen, 2005, pp. 41-42)

While Seth represented chaos and disorder and Horus representing cosmic order, the evolving theology of the period – which was focused on order and ma'at – achieved the necessary balance by linking the two cults. While Horus had been the victor over Seth in the mythology of the evolution of Egypt's kingship, the two were linked together – in the person of Pharaoh – providing a balance between chaos and order, and joining the Two Lands. (Wenke, 2009, pp. 244-245)

Pharaoh – divinity or only intermediary for the gods?

The period from 3500 to 3200 B.C. in Upper Egypt saw the development of "…regionally organised societies…" where an elite group of leading families emerged out of the population of each of these local proto cities to rule. Each of these groups was able to access "…wealth, power…" and prestige over that available to the remainder of the population. The sites where this social stratification occurred include Hierakonpolis, Naqada and Abydos. (Wenke, 2009, pp. 204-205)

The evolution of this stratification, according to Castillos (2009, p. 74) likely occurred as a result of four factors – population expansion; the ability of a core group to build

wealth; this group using that wealth to achieve political and social power; and then exerting that political control over less powerful and prosperous communities. The leading families became a "…hereditary elite…" passing power down through each generation, with the individual at the top of the social apex evolving from the position of "…village headman…" to ruler. (Andelkovic, 2008, pp. 1048-1049)

The idea of one man ruling all – people and geographic regions – culminated during the Naqada I/IIa period with the establishment of the concept of kingship. (Andelkovic, 2008, p. 1048) Realising the goal of ruling a tribe or geographic region was probably achieved by individuals prepared to use various means, including (but not limited to) bribes, threats and judicious alliances. (Castillos, 2009, p. 76) However, to both rule successfully *and* control the population meant the individual who was ruling – be they the village headman or the ruler – also had to establish an image of, *and be*, the personification of power and authority.

There are several avenues open to rulers with regards to specific methods which can be used to portray an image of power and strength, which then can be employed to control the populace – military force and control of food supplies are two examples. Power can also be achieved by controlling trade routes dealing with luxury goods, the resulting wealth being the source of the power for the ruling elite. Unfortunately, the limited surviving archaeological evidence from this period does not support any of these premises. (Perry, 2011, p. 1277) What evidence does exist points to the use of "…ideological power…" by the ruling elites as a means of exerting political control.

Elements used as ideological power in the late Predynastic Period included religious beliefs and cult practices, iconography to show the ruler as a powerful divinity and the promotion of a single unified political system – with the absolute ruler in charge of all he surveyed. (Mann in Perry, 2011, p. 1277), The evolution of these ideological and religious cultural characteristics, including the divine kingship which grew from the notion that only a divinity could rule, were unique to the Nile Valley proto states that became Egypt; no other contemporary Mediterranean state developed a similar system of government. (Rice, 2003, p. 3) The need to protect Egypt from chaos was personified by the concept of ma'at and "…Maatian ethics…" with the divine ruler being responsible for upholding "…cosmic order and society…" (Karenga, 2006, p. 30) Consequently, for each of the developing Predynastic Period proto-states, the only hope for survival and prosperity was under the control of a divine ruler, who was the

"…binding force of…unity…" and "…champion…against the forces of chaos". (Wilkinson, T., 2000, p. 58)

While limited, and the subject of debate as to its validity, evidence pointing to the ruler being viewed in the late Predynastic and Early Dynastic Periods as a powerful divinity exercising absolute power exists in the surviving iconography. The population believed that Egypt had been created by the gods when the world was created; Pharaoh, as the successor and descendent of the all-powerful gods, ruled by "…divine right…" and was therefore divine in his own right. (Frankfort, 1954, pp. 28-29)(Strudwick & Strudwick, 2011, KL 10697-10703) Thus, the iconography employed during this period supported and maintained this view; with the additional benefit of legitimising the political and religious focus of the ruling regime.

Pharaonic iconography and ritual ideology of the Pre-dynastic Period

In an age without any means for mass communication, and where image and display were the only methods of displaying wealth and power, rulers dressed for success – including regalia and weapons to ensure their subjects were in no doubt who was in charge. The earliest known image (c. 4000 B.C.) displaying this type of royal authority and power is that from a vase found in Tomb U-239 at Abydos (Figure 18); the ruler (figure at top right of Figure 18), who is carrying a mace and wearing plumes in his hair and an animal tail at his waist, is also depicted as larger than the figures of bound captives surrounding him. (Wilkinson, T., 2003, pp. 78-80)

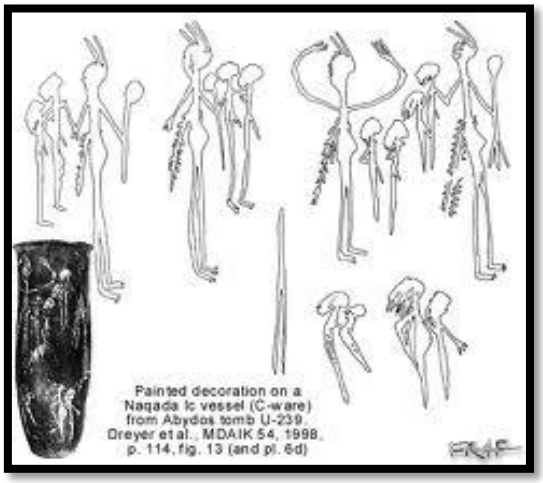


Figure 18 Images from vase in Tomb U-239,
Source: http://xoomer.virgilio.it/francescoraf/hesyra/Egyptgallery
Accessed 24 Aug 2013

The size differential between the images of the ruler and the bound captives is deliberately used to display the concept of supreme power, with the ruler having the power of life and death. The imagery of the figure in the centre right of Figure 18, with the arms raised above and hands pointing inward, is a common image from the Predynastic Period believed to signify a leading, or powerful, individual. (Garfinkel, 2001, pp. 246-247) Other images, from the beginning of the fourth millennium B. C., that have survived as rock drawings in Egypt's Eastern Desert (Figure 19) also show larger than life human figures, some of whom are wearing large elaborate headdress' and holding maces in their hands. (Wilkinson, T., 2003, p. 79)



Figure 19 Rock drawings from Wadi Hammamat Naqada I period,
Source: www.touregypt.net/featurestories/easterndesert,
Accessed 25 Aug 2013

The animal tail was linked during the Predynastic Period with the god Min, the "…bull god." As a bull (a white bull was the focus of worship at Min's cult centres at Gebtu and Khent-Min – Wilkinson, R., 2003, pp. 115-116), Min could crush his enemies into the ground (as with the allegory of the Narmer Palette with Narmer as a bull trampling conquered foes – Wright, 1985 , pp. 241-242); the wearing of the bull tail by the ruler is therefore another powerful visual image identifying the ruler as a god. (Baumgartel, 1975, p. 29) The depiction of the divine Pharaoh as a bull, where the bull is depicted in a prominent position and performing official duties, during the Predynastic and Early Dynastic Periods (Adams, 1988, p. 47) is another example supporting the premise of that Pharaoh was viewed as a god. Whether the images in Figures 18 and 19 are meant to convey the premise that the larger of the human figures in these drawings are divine beings is unknown; however the possibility that this is prehistoric imagery designed to show the ruler's divine status cannot be discounted.

As with the plumes in the hair of the figures in Figure 18 and 19, so elaborate headdresses continued to be a major imagery element signifying royal authority. The

use of large headdresses instantly made the individual wearing them appear taller, adding to the ruler's imposing persona. Primitive depictions of what became known as the Red Crown during Egypt's dynastic period exist in rock drawings at Site 18 at Wadi Qash; (Wilkinson, T., 2003, pp. 80-82) with a depiction of what became the White Crown (Figure 20) – thought to have been carved during either the Late Predynastic or Early Dynastic Periods – identified at Site 81 at Wadi Mahamid near Elkab. (Hendirckx et al, 2009, pp. 174-175)



Figure 20 Late Predynastic/Early Dynastic Period carving of White Crown,
Source: Section of Figure 5, Hendrickx et al, 2009, p. 175

The Red Crown is cited by Baumgartel, (1975, p. 28) as being "…considered to be the most ancient and exalted…" crown, that which was "…venerated as a goddess." If the Red Crown was identified with, and also as, a divinity, its use by the Predynastic rulers in their regalia could have been intended to demonstrate to the populace that the rulers were gods. Continued use of imagery of the Red Crown occurred during the course of the Naqada Period, as evidenced by the pottery shard in Figure 21, which dates from the Naqada IIa period.



Figure 21 Naqada IIa pottery shard with Red Crown, c. 3600 B C,
Source: www.ancient-egypt.co.uk/ashmolean/pages/2005-mar-11,
Accessed 24 Aug 2013

As the Predynastic Period continued, the iconography depicting the ruler as an all-powerful being continued its evolution. The Narmer Palette (Figure 22), the Scorpion Mace and the drawings from the Painted Tomb (Tomb 100) at Hierakonpolis (Figure 23) all include imagery of a larger than life ruler, triumphing over enemies in what was becoming the archetypal image of Egyptian kingship. (Rice, 2003, p. 107)(Kemp, 2007, pp. 92-97) The use of animal imagery – particularly animals recognised as being powerful and dangerous in their own right such as the lions in Figure 23 – also shows an expansion of the iconography of the superhuman ruler with the image of a male holding off two lions.



Figure 22 Reverse side of Narmer Palette,
Source: www.ancient-egypt.org
Accessed 28 Aug 2013

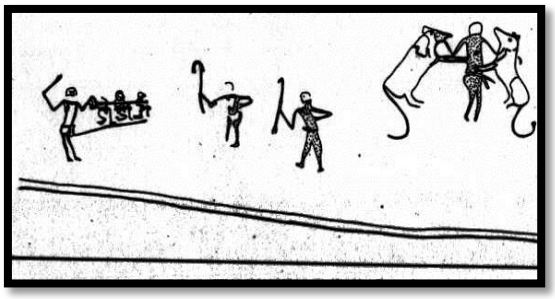


Figure 23 Images from Tomb 100 at Hierakonpolis,
Source: http://condor.depaul.edu/sbucking/tomb100dr.jpg
Accessed 28 Aug 2013

Another element supporting the notion of the Pharaoh as a divine being that originated in the Predynastic Period was the depiction of a falcon on a standard, with this image functioning as a "…ideogram of the word *nṯr* or god." Standards were borne before

Pharaoh during processions, as in Figures 24 and 25, with two falcon standards present in both figures. While the evidence is not conclusive, and the subject of debate among historians, Shalomi-Hen (2008, pp. 1011 & 1015-1017) has theorised that the presence of a falcon standard near the Pharaoh was used to indicate a divine entity, with that divinity – *nṯr* – being Pharaoh; and that this view was present during the period when concept of Egyptian kingship was evolving. Falcon standards, above the image of the Pharaoh, have been identified at the Dynasty 0 rock carvings at Nag el Hamdulab. (Hendricks, et al., 2012, p. 299)

Wengrow (2006, pp. 211-212) discusses the imagery of the falcon in the Narmer Palette (Figure 22), where the falcon, shown as a large and powerful entity, is leading '…by the nose…" the land. This image is in parallel with Narmer, who is holding his captive in a similarly humiliating and submissive manner. The use of the falcon imagery linked with the god Horus, alongside that of Pharaoh – where Pharaoh is subjugating his enemies and also in depictions of royal processions as in the rock carvings at Nag el-Hamdulab – are possible attempts by the artist to depict a royal *and* divine ruler.



Figure 24 Detail of Narmer's Mace head with standards
Source: www.iteror.org Accessed 13 Oct 2013



Figure 25 Detail of obverse side of Narmer Palette showing standards borne before Pharaoh.
Source: www.ancient-egypt.org Accessed 13 Oct 2013

Development of the ideology of the all-powerful, divine, ruler during the Predynastic Period included not only imagery and iconography, but also the evolution of a joint political/religious ideology which provided each of the ruling regimes of the proto states along the Nile Valley with the means by which they controlled their populace. The ruling regime of the cult centre of Hierakonpolis choreographed ritual activities, with the more important activities being led by the ruler, in a location that quickly assumed a sacred prominence of its own – thereby attracting worshippers to the site – with the activities designed to reinforce the "…sacred authority of the ruler." (Perry, 2011, pp. 1287-1288 & 1271)

Economic benefits flowed from the ritual activities, including from the local manufacture of pottery and flint ritual objects for the cult centre. The regime achieved political control of the region in conjunction with the development of religious ideology, with the establishment and perpetuation of "…sacred power…order…" and "…harmony symbolised by the Divine King." (Andelkovic, 2011, pp. 1225-1226)

Pharaonic Iconography and Ideology of the Early Dynastic Period

The political and religious iconography and ideology developed during the Predynastic Period continued after the unification of Egypt into one state under one Pharaoh. The kingship was exercised by each ruler through the intervention of Horus – divine successor to the first ruler of Egypt Re – as Horus was "…incarnate…" within each king. (Frankfort, 1954, pp. 49-50) The concept of the absolute, divine, ruler became inextricably linked with the state, which was "…integrated by the existence of the king…and brought together into a whole...around him (the king)." (Rice, 1997, pp. 86-87)

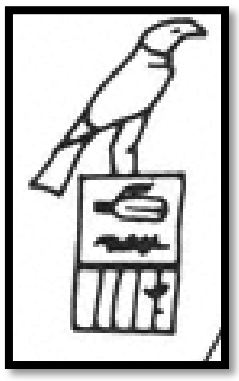


Figure 26 Serekh of King Den, portion of image from carved ivory label,
Source: www.publishing.cdlib.org, Accessed 31 Aug 2013
Image source – Spencer, 1980 in Whitney, D., *Masking the Blow: The Scene of Representation in Late Prehistoric Egyptian Art*, University of California Press, Berkeley, 1992

As the divine ruler, the iconography employed to project his image was aimed at emphasising his unique position. One example was the use of the serekh – a sacred device originating in the late Predynastic Period, within which was written the ruler's name – a privilege reserved solely for the ruler. As the ruler was the personification of Horus, the serekh was surmounted by a falcon. (Figure 26)

The ruler's personal regalia – as depicted on the Narmer Palette (Figure 27) and including the bull's tail – evolved during the Predynastic Period, but became in the Early Dynastic Period Pharaoh's standard royal costume. The Red Crown (now seen as representing Lower Egypt) was joined by the White Crown (representing Upper Egypt).

(Aldred, 2002, pp. 83-84) Rice (1997, p. 89) states that the crowns – which were "…Great of Magic..." – were integral components of the king's "…royal and divine status…"



Figure 27 Detail of Narmer Palette with royal placenta,
Source: http://faculty.ncc.edu, Accessed 1 Sep 2013

Another uniquely African facet supporting the notion of the divine ruler, and one originating during the Predynastic Period, was the "…cult of the Royal Placenta." (Rice, 2003, pp. 108-109)(Wilkinson, T., 2000, p. 199)(Long, 1963, p. 239) Evidence from the First Dynasty period for this cult is in a rock carving known as the Gebel Sheikh Suleiman Monument, which includes imagery of a placenta, or "Khons-sign". (Wlliams et al, 1987, pp. 263-264) Another rock carving (Figure 28), from Nag el-Hamdulab (near Aswan), dated to Dynasty 0, is thought to show a royal placenta standard (top left of Figure 2).

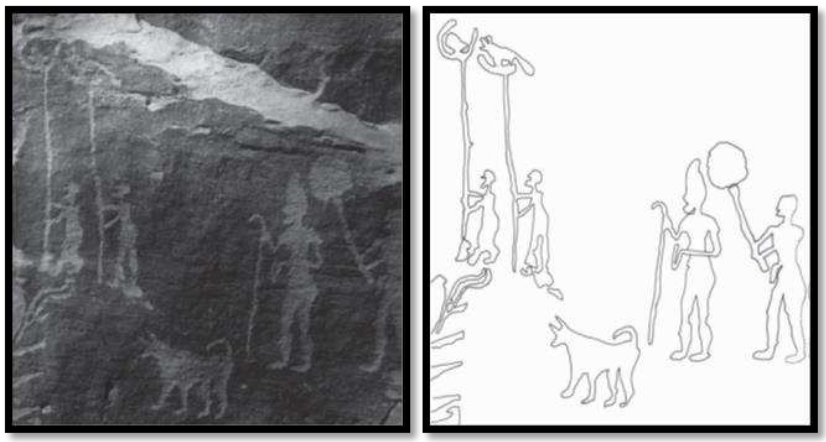


Figure 28 Late Predynastic-Early Dynastic Period carving
from Gharb Aswan (photo – Labib Hadachi),
Source: Figures 1 & 2 from Hendrickx et al, 2009, p. 170

Supporting evidence for this theory is in the second standard (on the right hand side at top left of Figure 2) identified as the "…Wepwawet…" standard; the Wepwawet standard also occurs in conjunction with the royal placenta standard on the Scorpion mace head and the Narmer palette and mace head. (Hendrickx et al, 2012, p. 298) The cult was so important that images of the king's placenta – the intimate, physical element which had nurtured and protected the king before birth and was viewed as both the king's twin and his ka (or spirit – David, 1982, p. 36) – were carried on standards before him during royal processions. (Figure 27) (Frankfort, 1978, pp. 70-71)(Roth, 1992, pp. 126-127) The placenta itself was likely stored during Pharaoh's lifetime, and then possibly destroyed after his death. (Cintron, 2007, pp. 15-16).

Along with the royal regalia, costume, crowns and important cults such as that of the Royal Placenta, the image of the superhuman ruler crushing his enemies (Figure 29) was now also a standard image for displaying his strength and divinity.

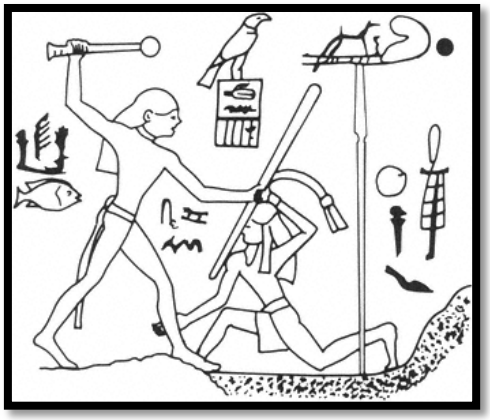


Figure 29 Carved ivory label of King Den, Dynasty I,
Source: www.publishing.cdlib.org, Accessed 31 Aug 2013
Image source – Spencer, 1980 in Whitney, D., *Masking the Blow: The Scene of Representation in Late Prehistoric Egyptian Art*, pp. 214, University of California Press, Berkeley, 1992

The joint religious/political ideology developed during the Predynastic Period, with the absolute ruler the sole individual able to liaise with the gods for the benefit of Egypt continued into the Early Dynastic Period. The primary role for each Pharaoh was to ensure ma'at – stability and prosperity within and outside Egypt – against the threat of disorder which was viewed as being an ever-present danger for Egypt. (Karenga, 2006, p. 30)(Strudwick & Strudwick, 2011, KL 10697-10703) The religious component of that role was fulfilled by Pharaoh making offerings at the temples to ensure the gods continued to smile on Egypt.

While Pharaoh was viewed as a god on earth and absolute ruler, even a divine being needed assistance to maintain ma'at in Egypt. As Pharaoh could not be at every temple in Egypt, priests were appointed to represent him. The political and administrative tasks were delegated, through the two chancellors for Lower and Upper Egypt, to the burgeoning bureaucracy established at the beginning of the Early Dynastic Period. This bureaucracy oversaw the management of Egypt, which included all land, construction and agricultural activities and the coordination of the collection, storage and distribution of all agricultural produce. (Aldred, 2002, pp. 86-87) While tasks were delegated to the priests and bureaucracy, and then down through the strata of Egyptian society to the farmers in the fields, all who lived in Egypt at this time knew, and accepted without question, that the divine king ruled them all.

Old Kingdom Egypt – The sunset of the divine king

The beginning of the Old Kingdom (Dynasties Three to Six, c. 2584 – 2117 B.C. (Dodson & Hilton, 2010, pp. 287-288) saw the full demonstration of the power of the divine king, exemplified with Sneferu – first ruler of the Fourth Dynasty – describing himself as the "…perfect god." (Wilkinson, T., 2010, p. 58) This demonstration of unlimited divine and political power, and wealth, was displayed in the construction of the pyramids, with Sneferu ultimately building the most pyramids of any Pharaoh from the Old Kingdom. (Tyldesley, 2009, pp. 38 & 45-46) The peak of pyramid building activity was during the Fourth Dynasty with the construction of the Giza pyramids, the last pyramid being that of Menkaura, last Pharaoh of the dynasty. This pyramid was smaller than those of his predecessors, and reflected the beginning of the loss of the absolute power and wealth for the Pharaoh's of the later Old Kingdom.

The loss of Pharaoh's divine status, wealth and political power during the latter stages of the Old Kingdom can be shown by the corresponding growth in influence, and power, of the nobility. During the Fourth Dynasty, the closest courtiers could come to making contact with Pharaoh was to kiss the ground he had walked on; during the Fifth Dynasty, as has been previously mentioned, favoured courtiers were now permitted to kiss Pharaoh's foot. (Aldred, 1988, p. 78) The nobility, now no longer exclusively comprised of cadet branches of the royal family, were securing wealth and power as a consequence of land grants and titles from Pharaoh. As time passed, lands and titles were passed down from father to son – not as favours from Pharaoh – thereby

diminishing the power and influence of the central government in the provincial areas. (Rice, 1997, p. 90)(Aldred, 2002, pp. 120-121)

The rise of the cult of Heliopolis, and the sun-god Re, further reduced Pharaoh's divine status from being Sneferu's "…perfect god." to now being merely one of many gods surrounding Re. The cult of Re was important enough for pharaonic funerary complexes from the later stages of the Old Kingdom to include both pyramids and sun temples. The combination of temple and pyramids was designed to "…maintain the cult of the king in relation to the cult of the supreme god." (Strudwick & Strudwick, 2011, KL 10863-10865) However, while the kingship was still seen as "…a divine and eternal office…" Re's cult was becoming more important, with the king losing power to the priests. (Strudwick & Strudwick, 2011, KL 10678-10690)

The reasons why Unas included the Texts in his pyramid, some of which describe Pharaoh as being all powerful, even over other gods – as in PT 180a and 180b "Unas is one who eats people and lives on gods…" and "Unas is the god senior to the senior ones." (Allen, 2005, p. 51-52) – are unlikely to ever be known. However, possible reasons (which are speculative) include that Unas, reacting to the loss of his personal prestige and divine status, sought to ensure one sacred custom existed for Pharaoh alone. Equally, the inclusion of the Texts in Unas' pyramid may have been motivated by religious concerns for his (Unas') well-being in the afterlife. There may also have been a political element in that Unas, via the Texts, wanted to reinforce to the priests – who would maintain his funerary cult after his death – of the ancient, and fundamental, concept that he, and *all* Pharaoh's, were "…of divine essence, a god incarnate…", (Frankfort, 1978, p. 5) and not merely Re's lackeys.

The Pyramid Texts – Pharaoh's guide book to immortality

Breasted (2011, p. 40) described the Texts as incorporating several themes, including funerary and offering rituals, hymns and prayers for the dead Pharaoh. More recent scholarship has viewed the Texts as more a practical manual than a "doctrinal treatise…" (Tobin, 1989, p. 2) and, as previously mentioned, a collection of works broadly divided into three categories – Offering and Insignia Rituals, Resurrection and Morning Rituals, and Personal Protection Spells and Rituals (Allen, 2005, pp. 5-6). The passages in each of these categories provide spells and prayers to enable the deceased Pharaoh to survive in the afterlife, in a manner equal to that which they enjoyed in life.

The Offering and Insignia Rituals provided nourishment and royal raiment; the Resurrection Ritual frees the soul of the deceased from the body and the Personal Protection Spells protect Pharaoh against malevolent forces in the afterlife.

As with all ritual activities in Egypt, there was nothing accidental or random about where the Texts were placed within the pyramid; they were placed in precise locations. Texts relating to Pharaoh's journey through the underworld were carved into the walls of the burial chamber, and the Texts relating to Pharaoh's resurrection into the walls of the antechamber, this chamber identified as the "…horizon, the place of rebirth…" (Wilkinson, T., 2010, pp. 88-89) Also, the importance of the Texts was not so much as in their content, but in what the intended outcome was with regard to the effect of each utterance. The Texts were "…not speculative, they were operative." (Hays, 2012, p. 13), and designed to produce specific effects and outcomes for Pharaoh. The Texts were also "…permanent recitations…" (Assmann, 2005, p. 239) words that would speak for the deceased Pharaoh once the priests had departed and the tomb was sealed.

One of the outcomes the Texts were designed to achieve was to provide the means by which the deceased Pharaoh could become a "…akh, literally an effective being." an entity which could live forever in the afterlife. (Allen, 2005, p. 7) The akh was a spiritual being "…made of light…" (Dodson & Ikram, 2008, p. 16), encompassing the decedent's ka and ba; the ka being the life energy that left the body on death and the ba being the "…soul or personality…" of the deceased. Only after the ka and ba were reunited could the akh form and the deceased live forever. Living forever for Pharaoh meant achieving his destiny and spending eternity with the gods. (Mercer, 2002, KL 99-104)

Offering and Insignia Rituals

As Pharaoh needed food and wine in life, so he would require them in the afterlife. The Offering and Insignia Texts were located on the north walls of the burial chamber and, as in life, began with the standard ritual preparations for a meal – these including libations and ritual cleansing with "…incense and salt water…" (Allen, 2005, pp. 5-6 & 20) In PT 20 incense is placed on the fire as the "…scent of Horus's eye…" is disseminated to Unas; with Unas cleansing his mouth in PT 21 with "…these cool waters."

Along with the incense and salt water, the preparations also included the "…opening of the mouth…" rites, these enabling the deceased Pharaoh to receive the offerings. The psš-kf knife, originally an ancient flint artefact from Egypt's Predynastic Period, was an important element in these rituals. The psš-kf knife was put to the deceased as a spell; PT 25 and 26 telling Unas "…I have fixed your jaws spread for you." and Osiris then stating "…Let me part your mouth for you" (Allen, 2005, p. 20); these spells facilitating the opening of Pharaoh's mouth. (Roth, 1992, p. 113)

Pharaoh could now eat and drink, with the offerings, as in PT's 32-44 (Allen, 2005, pp. 20-21), including beer, wine, milk, bread, meat, vegetables and fruit. To ensure Pharaoh's satisfaction in the afterlife, the Texts also included spells such as "…contentment be your lot (PT 32)…" and "…let everything be for his body (PT 38)..." (Allen, 2005, p. 21)

As with food and drink, so with insignia and regalia; items – such as the Red Crown and the Bull's Tail – had been an integral part of Pharaoh's costume from the Predynastic Period through to the Old Kingdom. Insignia and regalia helped to identify the ruler; they were certainly required for Pharaoh in his afterlife so the gods would have no doubt *he* was Pharaoh. The Insignia Texts, specifically PT 141 from the tomb of Teti – after calling him to get "…dressed in your body and come to them." – then ensured all of the accoutrements of the royal regalia were provided; "A king-given offering of all your insignia…leopard skin…kilt…reed sandals…water-lily-bud sceptre…" and "…your staff…" (Allen, 2005, p. 71) After Teti is given his insignia, a further spell to ensure his contentment – as with the Offering Texts – is extended "How content is your situation as you become akh, oh Teti, among your brothers the gods…" (Allen, 2005, p. 71) The Offering and Insignia Texts therefore had two primary goals, to provide the Pharaoh with his provisions for the afterlife, and ensure his contentment with the offerings.

Resurrection and Morning Rituals

Pharaoh's resurrection, and rebirth as an akh, was essential if he was to live forever with the gods. The goal of the Resurrection Texts, located on the south wall of the burial chamber, was to ensure this occurred. (Mercer, 2002, KL 101-102) These texts encompass several elements that the deceased Pharaoh had to undergo before he could ascend to live with the gods. These elements include ritual purification as the "…body

and soul had to be pure…" before Pharaoh could achieve immortality (Davis, 1977, p. 163). One of the purification spells, directly linking Pharaoh with Re, is that of Pharaoh cleansing himself in the Field of Rushes. The morning ritual of the sun-god Re was to cleanse himself in the Field of Rushes, with Pharaoh joining him "…Unas has become clean in the Marsh of Reeds…" before ascending to the sky. (PT 164 in Allen, 2005, p. 43)(Lichtheim, 2006, pp. 33-34)

Ensuring Pharaoh's physical body survived was another critical element; with the body, or a statue of the deceased if the physical body was lost, necessary to ensure Pharaoh's survival in the afterlife. (Frankfort, 1954, pp. 90-91) The body was the primary link between the decedent and the world of the living, as the body could receive all offerings provided to sustain the decedent in the afterlife. (David, 2002, pp. 116-117) As a dead body obviously could not move, PT 196 exhorts Teti to "…Stand up...Nephthys has collected all your limbs…Seshat…has made them sound for you…be alive." (Allen, 2005, pp. 80-81) These spells provided the deceased Pharaoh with the means to reform and reanimate his dead body, and allow his journey to the afterlife.

The morning Rituals in the Texts were likely akin to the ceremony associated with Pharaoh's activities during his life where he was woken, robed and fed. (Te Velde, 1995, p. 1741) As the highest ranking, and divine, individual in Egypt, all of these activities would have been conducted with the appropriate level of formality and ritual, led by the "…Supervisor of the pr-dwht…" the pr-dwht being the "…Toilet-chamber…" where these morning activities were conducted. (Blackman, 1918, p. 152) Pharaoh's death did not eliminate the need for these rituals, with the Texts describing various activities, including anointing "…Take to his arm and to his head, that he may be anointed with it…" (PT 36); robing "…receive your dazzling garment…" (PT 220) and eating "…accept…the bread-loaf of the gods…" (PT 391) (Allen, 2005, pp. 141, 85 & 272).

Personal Protection Spells and Rituals

The personal spells for the deceased Pharaoh included those to guide his spirit out of the tomb each day to ascend to join the gods, and those to protect him against malevolent forces in the afterlife. (Allen, 2005, pp. 6-7) The spells to assist Pharaoh's spirit follow on from those designed to purify his soul and reform his corpse; only then can Pharaoh leave his tomb. Davis (1977, pp. 166-167) discusses two themes in the Texts that focus

on assisting Pharaoh in his "…mythic passage: ritual transmission and ritual identification." Ritual transmission is where the life force of the Pharaoh is borne from the tomb by a force *other* than one which is "...a personification of any form of the King…" Examples in the Texts of such forces include PT 176 where Unas ascends on "…Isis's thighs, Unas will climb on Nephthys's thighs." and "…on the ladder that his father the Sun has made for him." (Allen, 2005, pp. 49-50) Ritual identification is where Pharaoh assumes the qualities of the gods, and then utilises those qualities and powers to ascend, as in PT 207 (Allen, 2005, p. 56) where Sothis "…has flown Unas to the sky…" and Unas's "…seat is with you, Sun…"

Malevolent forces present in the afterlife included serpents and scorpions, two creatures known in the Nile Valley for presenting a deadly threat to those in the land of the living. A primordial serpent – Kematef – appears in the earliest versions of the Creation Myths; emerging out of the waters of chaos, perpetually attacking whatever came into its path. (Dunand & Zivie-Coche, 2004, p. 52)(Wilkinson, R., 2003, p. 221) Scorpions were known as creatures of religious importance from the Predynastic Period, with the many images of scorpions found at Hierakonpolis cited as substantiation by Hendricks and Friedman (2003, p. 95) of the presence of a Hierakonpoliton scorpion cult. Also, and perhaps as a consequence of their lethality, scorpions were seen as a "…potent symbol of royal aggression." (Wilkinson, T., 2000, p. 299) In order to defend both his spirit and his corpse from these creatures – who lived in the ground where his body was resting – the deceased Pharaoh was provided with spells ordering them away from his presence including PT 1 and 2 "…Monster, lie down, crawl away!", "Overturn yourself, drive into the earth…" (Allen, 2005, p. 17)

The Cannibal Hymn

While the main body of Texts included in each tomb provided guidance, offerings and protection to Pharaoh, one unique anomaly is the Cannibal Hymn. This Text, which was only used in the tombs of Unas and Teti (Eyre, 2002, pp. 11 & 142-143), depicts in graphic detail Pharaoh cannibalising the gods. This Text was in the tomb's antechamber, where the spells for the rebirth of Pharaoh's spirit were located (Allen, 2005, p. 50), and its sole premise was Pharaoh's omnipotent power over all beings, including the gods – Pharaoh is the *only* power that matters. PT 180a describes Pharaoh as he who "…eats the bowels (of the gods) when they have come from the Isle of Flame with their belly filled with magic…" and he who "…eats people, who lives on gods."

(Allen, 2005, pp. 50-51) Pharaoh needed to kill, and eat, the gods so he can absorb and seize their power, called the "…heka…" with this power then becoming an integral part of Pharaoh's being. (Dunand & Zivie-Coche, 2004, p. 123)(Eyre, 2002, p. 57 & 60)

The origins of this utterance are unknown, but its savage language, as in PT 180a, "…Gory All Over is the one who binds them for him…Shezmu is the one who will butcher them for Unas…" (Allen, 2005, pp. 80-81) is reminiscent of the ritual sacrifices, animal and human, known to have been conducted at Hierakonpolis in the Predynastic Period. (Romer, 2012, pp. 82-84) The lack of reference in the Cannibal Hymn to the burgeoning solar cult was cited by Faulkner (1924, p. 102) and Breasted (2011, pp. 54-55) as supporting evidence for this utterance to pre-date the Old Kingdom. The solar cult was, from the Fourth Dynasty, becoming more prominent (Rice, 2003, p. 199) and likely would have been included in the Text if it had been authored at this time. The prominence of the gods named in the Text – Geb and Orion – also dates from before the Old Kingdom.

Whether cannibalism was practised in the Predynastic or Early Dynastic Periods is disputed. Murray, (1956, pp. 90-92) cites evidence for cannibalism from Amratian-Naqada I era burials in human bones found broken or split, with contents gouged out. Recent scholarship (Midant-Reynes, 2000, p. 188), discussed the opposing theories of Petrie and Hoffmann (1993, p. 116) and Davis in *Cemetery T at Naqada* (MDAIK, 39, 1983, p. 27) as to whether teeth marks on Naqada-era human bones were evidence of cannibalism. Hoffmann cites the lack of burning on the bones found by Petrie as evidence refuting cannibalism, but does discuss alternative options for the bone evidence being either from multiple burials, or from human sacrifice.

Regardless of whether cannibalism occurred at this time in Egyptian history, the concept may have been used as a potent metaphor for strength and power. Given the political situation during the latter stages of the Old Kingdom, with Pharaoh losing power and influence to the priests, the use of this Text by Unas and Teti may have been designed to send an unequivocal message regarding their divine status to the priests. The fact that this Text was not used again after Teti is a possible indication that the priests did get the message and, in order to rebut the image of Pharaoh as being all powerful – even over the gods – ensured the Text was not used again.

Pharaoh and the Pyramid Texts

The discovery of the Texts by Maspero (Hornung, 1999, pp. 1-2) provided to the modern world the first primary source evidence of the early evolution of theology and religion from Egypt's Predynastic Period through to the Old Kingdom. The "…culture of death…" (Midant-Reynes, 2000, pp. 254-255) that began in the 5th millennium B.C. with simple graves, a few grave goods, and spells and prayers recited to protect the deceased (Rice, 2003, p. 208), had developed by the Old Kingdom into the elaborate burials provided for Pharaoh. While the origin of the Texts were simple prayers recited at burials in the Predynastic Period, as time progressed these prayers became part of Egypt's religious and mortuary traditions. By the time of the death of Unas (c. 2345 B.C. – Malek, 2000, p. 100) the reading of this mortuary literature (Assmann, 2005, p. 238) at the burial was likely a routine event, but Unas went one step further and had the prayers carved into his tomb.

The sacred nature of the Texts, their ability to provide for, and protect, Pharaoh on his journey to join the gods, were probably one reason why Unas included them in his tomb. The Texts were a significant component of the religious and theological philosophy that underpinned all sacred activities in Old Kingdom Egypt, and which had evolved in tandem with the social and political developments in the Nile Valley from the Predynastic Period onwards. The worship of what became Egypt's pantheon of gods probably began with the veneration of local divinities seen as able to control nature and the elements, including Min, the storm god. (Wilkinson, R., 2003, p. 12) The number of divinities increased over time, with spells in the Texts reflecting the divine pantheon. Specific gods achieved national prominence, including Horus and Ptah. (Wilkinson R., 2003, pp. 16-19) The necessity to placate all of Egypt's gods, and so prevent Egypt slipping into chaos – that which had existed before Creation – led to the evolution of the concept of ma'at, "…justice and cosmic order." for all in Egypt. (Wilkinson, R., 2003, pp. 150-152) Pharaoh, as the divine ruler, was responsible for upholding ma'at. (Karenga, 2006, p. 30)

The evolution of one man to rule them all – the concept of Pharaoh as a divine ruler – developed from the social stratification that occurred during the growth of the settlements along the Nile Valley and was a concept unique to Egypt. (Rice, 2003, p. 3) The ideological elements used to maintain this concept included religious beliefs and cult practices, iconography, imagery and regalia, and the development of a single,

unified political system. (Mann in Perry, 2011, p. 1277) Consequently, the establishment of the system of rule by a divine ruler was promoted as the only option to save Egypt from the forces of chaos, and so maintain ma'at. (Wilkinson, T., 2000, p. 58)

While Pharaoh, from the late Predynastic through to the Fourth Dynasty, was viewed as a divinity, by the latter stages of the Old Kingdom this view was fading; a significant factor in the reduction in political and religious status for Pharaoh being the commensurate increase in the influence of the nobility and the priests. Along with individual gods achieving national prominence, the priests appointed to run the temples – particularly those temples that became major cult centres such as Hierakonpolis and Heliopolis – also gained power and influence. The ascendency of the cult of Heliopolis and the god Re during the Fourth Dynasty, when Pharaoh adopted the title of *son* of Re, was the beginning of the end for Pharaoh as a divine ruler.

Unas, seeing his power and divine status diminishing and seeking avenues to redress this situation, may have used the Texts in his tomb to provide him with a unique level of protection for his journey to the afterlife. It was also an opportunity to assert his authority and establish a sacred prerogative, one reserved *solely* for Pharaoh. The use of the Cannibal Hymn supports this assertion; the brutal, graphic, descriptions of Pharaoh devouring the gods and being in command of all he surveyed – both in the land of the living and in the land of the dead – is a bald statement of power. After the hymn was included in Teti's pyramid, the priests – possibly seeing in it a threat to their own position – likely ensured it was not used again.

This attempt by Unas to reinvigorate Pharaoh's divinity and power was doomed to failure. Time and history were against him and this sacred prerogative for Pharaoh only endured during the 6th Dynasty, ending when the wives of Pepy II – Neith, Iput II and Wedjebetni – had the Texts carved into their pyramids. (Allen J. P., 2005, p. 1) The evolution of Egypt's religion, theology and mortuary cult continued after the Old Kingdom. However, the essence of the ritual spells offered to assist the dead, including Pharaoh, in their journey to the afterlife was that which originated in the villages of the Nile Valley in the 5th millennium B C, and which survived to be inscribed and discovered in the pyramid of Unas.

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